

Restoring Family Trees

Tree Tag # 914

by Garrett Brownlee for Dr. Joshua King's ENG 2301: British Literature class, Fall 2025

This reflection is part of a series of "Tree Stories" by Baylor students that take **root** in their observations about a tree on campus, **branch** into connections between their tree and their experiences and education, and **leaf out** into a creative response to the tree.

Welcome: For many people, their biggest concern is of a failure to leave behind a legacy...afraid to be forgotten. Well, many trees face this very concern these days, with their sacrifices for us going largely unrecognized by those of us who enjoy all the amazing things they have to give! Many of us pass trees everyday which we do not give any attention/thought to. My hope is that by hearing my story, and seeing these same ideas being reflected in other well-known literary works, that you are inspired to begin giving more conscious attention to the trees in your surrounding environment. I encourage you go so far as to begin forming relationships with trees, just as I and many before me have done.

Roots (Tree Assignment #1): For this assignment, I knew that I wanted to pick a tree in the place most important to me on our campus. This tree, located right next to Baylor's Browning Armstrong Library, is a tree that I've never truly appreciated before taking this class, despite spending most of time over the last three years in its presence. The first thing I noticed was its odd shape: there was noticeably more vegetation on the right side of the tree, but it also seemed to thin out towards the top (as if it thrived in older days and has since been progressively struggling with the passing of time). Secondly, there is an electrical box on the side of the tree (which also goes underground, therefore affecting the tree's "root system") which provides us students who study here with both light and electricity, granting us the ability to improve ourselves. Lastly, I noticed after looking at Baylor's "Sustainability Map" that this tree was noted as being in "poor condition" (due to some exposed wood sites), and has since (being recorded on the site) lost multiple limbs as they've essentially cut off the entire left side of the tree. At its own expense, the tree still stands to serve those who are blessed to sit underneath its shaded presence. This tree, being from the genus "Quercus Virginiana," has a special place in the heart of Texans (this tree is often used for the purpose of landscaping). That being said, it can be found all throughout the southern Coastal plains (Virginia to Texas), but they are increasingly found as you travel towards the Gulf Coast. Beyond landscaping though, these trees used to be a lot more intertwined with humanity as people used its very strong wood for wagon-wheels and other carpentry tools. Fun fact, the quality and curved shape of this tree's wood made it perfect for building the "Old Ironsides" when they refitted in during the 1980's when these trees were dying from Oak Wilt Fungus! I honestly hate to use this example, because I feel like it is one from our "literary forest" that is overused. However, this tree truly reminds me of the "The Dream of the Rood" because it is basically a simile to Jesus Christ and his crucifixion for the forgiveness of

our sins. This tree bundled up in harmful electricity and chopped up (to prevent overcrowding of trees and prevent building damage). Yet despite the tree's injury and general poor treatment from those who utilize it, it still serves us to this day. Us students worship this tree when we use its electricity and is kind of like the Rood explaining Christ to the post Anglo-Saxon culture in the example of trees (which they well understand).

Word count: 457

Branches (Tree Assignment #2): Ever since my very first-time visiting Tree #914 for "Tree Assignment Part 1," I have returned (on numerous occasions) to work and study underneath my tree at the Garden of Contentment. My initial thoughts are always different, as I perceive new things each time that I revisit my tree with "fresh eyes." However, I'm always brought back to the very same thought, the same thought/concept that I discussed in my first submitted reflection: how Tree #914 has visibly suffered at the expense of servicing us humans. After discussing Balai as an entire class on Friday, and with English being my last course of the day, I immediately went to the Garden of Contentment after school so I could finish all my assignments due that night (before the chaos of Friday-night ensued). As a result of our class discussion, combined with the fact that I had not visited my tree for multiple days, I approached my tree that afternoon with "fresh eyes." They helped me to see a new connection between my tree (as well as my experience with it) and our "literary forest," which was that the life/experience of my tree parallels that of the silk-cotton tree in the story Balai written by Rabindranath Tagore. The tree of this story, which Balai holds dear to his heart, is felled at the end of the story. However, as we discussed in class, this only occurs after Balai relocated to Shimla (and then later England). Most likely, Tagore wrote the story in this exact way to instill in us readers that Balai's very love for the tree itself served as both the figurative and the literal "trunk" for the silk-cotton tree. Once Balai's uncle realized that Balai's connection to the tree was severed by him moving away, the uncle made the decision to finally cut down the tree after years of being told "no" for Balai's sake. Additionally, the mindset of Balai's aunt began to change: "And she kept thinking that Balai must have outgrown all those things he had left behind" (Tagore, 653). With Balai gone, the tree having no literal voice, and the tree no longer mattering to the aunt (she only cared for the tree when Balai was around), eventually the appreciation for the silk-cotton tree declined greatly (until it was felled). Balai was the only reason the tree mattered. Similar to Tagore's short story, my tree has declined visibly in its health (documented over the recent years by Baylor students) as people have thought increasingly less about the wellbeing of Tree #914. More specifically, somebody installed an electrical box on my tree which runs under the ground, and my guess is they probably knew the electricity might interfere with the tree's biology/health...but still decided to install it, despite the fact. Even if the former is not true, people since then have become cognizant of this tree's declining health when they record the tree's health annually, but nobody has thought to remove the problem. The only way the tree will ever remove that harm is when a person cares enough to think about the tree (to have somebody who can stand up for it, because the tree matters to that person). Unless people stop by and enjoy the electricity and shade provided by the tree, AND think about the tree which is providing it, the poor tree will

remain forgotten about until somebody cares enough (like me or Balai). Not only will it's sacrifice be forgotten, but the tree will remain unappreciated and abused with more electrical lines likely to be added with time and additional limbs are likely to be removed.

Word count: 603

Branches (Tree Assignment #3): Building upon my reflection from the second part of our “tree reflections,” my most recent visit to my tree left me pondering how we can reverse the damage done to the tree, or at least begin to improve its health. Originally, my best thought was centered around re-establishing the worship of trees (and hopefully this tree specifically) in the students and staff of Baylor’s campus. Thinking back to “Dream of the Rood” from the semester’s beginning, it used to be quite common for people/communities to worship trees...but that died when the Romans took over and changed the previous Anglo-Saxon religion/culture (where they worshipped many things which were not Christ...like trees!). However, trying to get busy student to try and care about trees in their limited free time is not likely to produce any meaningful results. However, I spontaneously made a connection when reading “Underland” by Robert MacFarlane two days ago, right before our class. I realized there was another opportunity/method that was a lot more promising as it was measurable and didn’t require the difficulties involved in instilling habits/desires in humans directly. Instead of trying to get the Baylor community to care, maybe we could use the family of trees which surround it and begin restoring its health at its source (which remains unseen and underground), as MacFarlane’s dying friend explained: “...when one of their number was sickening or under stress, they could share nutrients by means of an underground system that conjoined their roots beneath the soil, thereby sometimes nursing the sick tree back to health” (MacFarlane, 1). I think this quote from MacFarlane’s work may hold the secret in caring for my dying tree. For my creative response, I will be creating an informative and persuasive video. This video will inform my viewers on (at least) 3 main things: what is the “wood wide web” which MacFarlane discusses, why we should care about it, and the underlying process of how it works. Ideally, my video will instill inspiration within individuals to take action towards “helping” the “wood wide web,” and more specifically, trees in which we obviously observe a decline in health. I will compare the anatomy of trees to that of the human body to emphasize just how similar we are. Additionally, just like MacFarlane did in “Understory,” I will also touch on how the language of mammals and plants are interweaved. Next, I will give a visual demonstration on how this “wood wide web” works, because people rarely care about things which they fail to understand or sympathize with. Lastly, I will visualize just how dependent our health (as humans) is on these underground plant communities. To conclude the video, I’ll end with by emphasizing my closing remark: Restore our surrounding trees by incorporating it as a part of our family, as well as administering care for the other members of the family in which it belongs to (the other trees, fungi, etc).

Word count: 487